REOILING THE POLL MACHINERY

At the party's national executive in mid-January, the BJP extended party chief Nadda's tenure till June next year despite the poll debacle in his home state, Himachal Pradesh. Insiders say the loss got buried in the celebrations over the party's biggest ever win in Gujarat. The buzz is the leadership is actively discussing an organisational rejig along with a Union cabinet reshuffle, with some cabinet ministers "withdrawn for organisational work". Sources say the party has asked 10 ministers (who are currently Rajya Sabha MPs) to look for constituencies to contest the 2024 Lok Sabha election. The BJP has drawn up a list of 160 Lok Sabha seats where the party candidates either lost or won marginally in 2019 (of these seats, 25 were contested by allies who have since quit the NDA). Full-time party workers, or *vistaraks*, have been appointed in all these constituencies to identify areas that require attention, resolve rivalries and build up the booth-level units. The constituencies are bundled into geographic clusters, with 44 Union ministers given charge.

All the states have been asked to update the *panna pramukhs* and *panna samitis* (the party's famous booth-level workers), with around 1.03 million polling booths identified. In 2017, then party president Shah had laid a similar plan for 120 seats; the BJP won roughly 30 per cent of them in 2019. Now Nadda is targeting a win percentage of 50 per cent in such seats.

THE PARTY HAS A LIST OF 160 LS SEATS THAT WILL RECEIVE SPECIAL FOCUS. OUT OF THEM, 25 WERE CONTESTED BY FORMER ALLIES IN 2019

The BJP has divided the states and Union territories into three categories—A, B and C—for the purpose of the elections. Tier A has states like Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, MP, where the party is in power either on its own or with allies. The focus here is to make sure the central and state schemes reach all *labharthi*s or beneficiaries. In Tier B, where BJP is the principal opposition, like in Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and West Bengal, leaders will be creating awareness about central schemes while exposing the state's inefficiencies. In Tier C states, where the party has potential (such as Punjab, Telangana and Kerala), new allies among new caste groups and PM Modi's goodwill is the fallback plan.

In 2019, the BJP put an age limit of 75 years for party candidates. If it sticks to the condition, the party will have to look for replacements of about 30 MPs.

STRENGTHENING NARRATIVES, WALKING THE TALK

BJP leaders acknowledge that unemployment is the biggest challenge before it as it sets out to face the electorate. Equally worrying is the shrinking spending power of a middle class that is already reeling under the consequences of Covid-related lockdowns. It has made issues such as fuel prices, inflation and even the opposition's demand for a return to the old pension scheme (OPS) for government staff seem all the more relevant.

PM Modi has made it clear to the BJP leadership as well as state chief ministers that he will not budge on fiscal reforms. However, there are murmurs within leaders in the party that a decision will have to be taken on two agendas at least—moving back to the OPS, and assessing the damage caused by pursuing the armed forces recruitment programme, Agniveer. Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra and what impact it has had in the five poll-bound states—Karnataka, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, MP and Rajasthan—is also being analysed. There are 180-odd Lok Sabha seats where the BJP takes the Congress head-on; in others, they are part of multi-cornered contests. That said, the party is taking out its own walkathons in these states, which should neutralise matters a bit.

GROUPING, REGROUPING

Three prominent allies—the then united Shiv Sena under Uddhav Thackeray in Maharashtra, Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal-United (JD-U) in Bihar and the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akai Dal in Punjab—have moved out of the NDA since 2019. In Maharashtra, Sena rebel and now CM Eknath Shinde has redressed the balance to an extent with his coup, bringing the bulk of party legislators and parliamentarians back into the NDA fold. However, it remains an unknown quantity electorally, even though the Election Commission giving it both the party name and the bow and arrow symbol is a big win. The first test will be the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) election, over which the Uddhav group will fight tooth and nail to retain control.

The party has adopted a wait-and-watch approach in Bihar. Former deputy CM from the BJP, Sushil Modi, says, "We can sense that Nitish is uncomfortable in the new alliance [with the Rashtriya Janata Dal]. He betrayed the public mandate and the confidence BJP had shown in him. Now there is no space for him." Another BJP leader from Bihar claims that the JD(U) will collapse on its own and hints that a substantial part of the leadership is keen to work with the BJP. In 2019, when the NDA included the JD(U) and the late Ramvilas Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (LJP), it swept 39 of the state's 40 Lok Sabha seats. Of these, the BJP won 17 seats, and is now targeting another eight.

The party is also redrawing its plans for West Bengal, Odisha and Telangana. RSS pracharak-turned-neta Bansal is again the master conductor, overseeing the preparations for 2024 in the three states. The BJP has taken a confrontationist approach with the ruling establishment in Bengal and Telangana while the plan is to wait out Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik and grow gradually in Odisha. The party had done well for itself in these states in 2019, bagging 18 of the 42 LS seats in Bengal, eight of the 21 in Odisha and four of the 17 in Telangana. It will be hoping to do even better in the 2024 general election. ■